



Even More XP Secrets

Here are some things you thought you couldn't do in XP

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We won't waste much time with this introduction, so here it is—another round of tips and tricks that will improve performance, stability and sort little annoyances in XP, among other things. *Statutory warning: Playing with your Registry can be injurious to your PC's health.*

System Volume Information

If you use System Restore, you must have



Here is the error you'll see when trying to access the System Volume Information

noticed the System Volume Information folders in the root of each of your drives. This folder stores the files used by System Restore. Their sizes can sometime balloon to gigabytes, because System Restore doesn't delete your older restore points when creating a new one. Moreover, every time you try to access the folder, you get the *Access Denied* error. Oh, and you can't delete the folder, either. So what do you do when you want to view its contents?

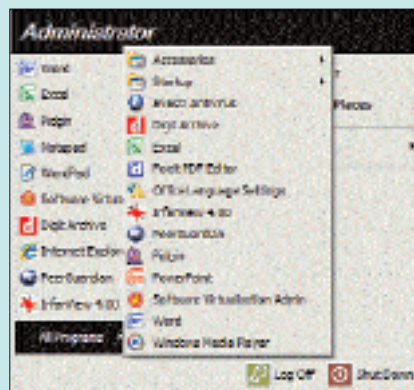
In an Explorer Window, go to Tools > Folder Options > View. Here, choose Show Hidden Files and Folders. Uncheck Hide Protected Operating System Files and Use Simple File Sharing.

You should now be able to access the System Volume Information folder; if not, you'll have to add yourself to the list of users allowed to access the folder. Right-click on System Volume Information and go to Properties > Security. Click Add under Groups or User names and enter your username in the dialog that appears. Click OK, and in the bottom half of the Security tab, grant yourself all the permissions.

Sort Menus Alphabetically

Start the Registry editor: Start > Run > regedit > [Enter]. Navigate to HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\MenuOrder

Right click on the MenuOrder folder, choose Permissions; go to Advanced in the new window that pops up, and uncheck the entry Inherit from parent the permission entries that apply to child objects. Include these with entries explicitly defined here. A security dialog box will open up; choose Copy. This will take you back to the Advanced Security Settings for MenuOrder dialog. Click OK here. In the Permissions dialog, uncheck Full Control in your account and security groups. Don't change the Read permission. Reboot the computer and all your menus will be alphabetically sorted.



The start menu gets sorted automatically, too

Increasing Internet Bandwidth

Windows XP reserves 20 per cent of your Internet bandwidth for Quality of Service. This is unnecessary, and can be disabled:

□ Open the Group Policy Editor: Start > Run > gpedit.msc > [Enter]

□ In the left-hand column in the window, navigate to Computer Configuration > Administrative Templates > Network > QoS Packet Scheduler.

□ In the right column, double-click Limit reservable bandwidth and select Enabled.



Increase your bandwidth by 20 per cent

□ Change the Bandwidth Limit to 0 and click OK.

Getting Rid Of The “Unread Email Messages” Message...

...on the Welcome Screen, that is. Here's how to do it:

□ Start the Registry Editor: Start > Run > regedit > [Enter]

□ Navigate to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion

□ Right-click on the CurrentVersion key and select New > Key. Name this UnreadMail.

□ Right-click on the blank area on the right side, and select New > DWORD Value. Call it MessageExpiryDays and give it a value of 0.

□ You may need to log off or restart for the changes to take effect.

Modifying the “Internet” Key On Internet Keyboards

You can change what programs you want to launch with the Internet key:

□ Open the Registry Editor and navigate to HKEY_LOCAL_MACHINE\SOFTWARE\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Explorer\AppKey\7

□ Right-click in the right column and create a new String called ShellExecute

□ Set the value as the application path, for example, C:\Program Files\Opera\Opera.exe. If you want to disable the key, delete the value from ShellExecute and leave it blank.

Open Explorer With A Single Pane

When you use [Windows] + [E] to open a Windows Explorer window, it opens in the two-pane layout. To have it open with a single pane by default, do the following.

□ In the Registry Editor, navigate to HKEY_CLASSES_ROOT\Folder\shell\explore\ddeexec

□ Double-click on (Default) and change the string to [ViewFolder("%1", %I, %S)] (including the brackets)

□ To revert to the double-pane window, set (Default) to [ExploreFolder("%1", %I, %S)]

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GOOGLE SERVICES



Google's all but taken over our online lives now—can you imagine doing anything without it?

PICASA

Download Albums From Picasa Web Albums

Photos that you see on Picasa Web Albums can be downloaded directly to the Picasa program without having to manually save each photo from within your browser. When on an album page, look for a link on the left side that says Download Album; confirm the download, and once it's complete, you can view all the downloaded albums by clicking on the Downloaded Album link on the left.

Upload Your Albums

One of the biggest and the most important feature of Picasa is its integration with Google's online photo hosting service—Picasa Web. Click on the Sign in to Web Albums link on the top right of the Picasa window to log in to the service—use your Google user ID and password. Once signed in, select the images you want to upload and click the Web Album button at the bottom. Give a title to the album and other description if needed. Select the resolution you want so that the images can be resized, and choose whether you want to make the album public or private. Click OK and the images will be uploaded.

Creating Albums With Starred Photos

Just like in Gmail and Google Reader, you can “star” important photos. Browse to the folders or albums where you have all your photos. Select the ones you want

and click the Star icon at the bottom of the screen. When you're done, go to File > New Album and give it a name and description. Now click on Starred Photos, select all the images and drag them into your newly-created album.

Getting More Organised

When you install Picasa and run it for the first time, it asks you whether you want to scan your entire hard drive or just scan your My Documents folder. All the photos on the hard drive appear as folders and albums on the left and there's no real way of identifying which folders they belong to on your hard drive. Sometimes, unnecessary images like ones from your browser cache folders also make their way into the list. The first thing to do is to manually enter the paths that you want to scan. You can do this by going to Tools > Folder Manager. Choose the folders you don't want, select the Remove from Picasa radio button and click OK. Add any folders that Picasa may have left out in the same manner.

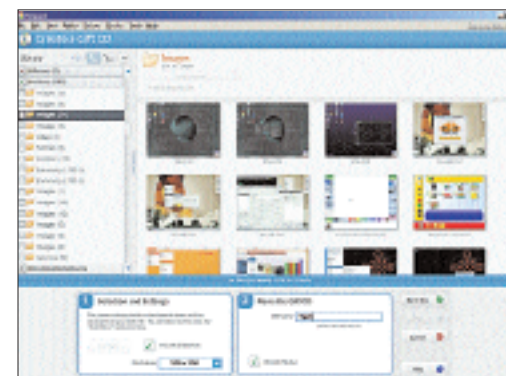
Another way you can see from where Picasa has listed all the photos is to go to View > Folder View > Tree View.

Backing Up Photos

Every now and again, your hard drive is bound to get clogged with photos that you've taken and it is a good idea to keep backing them up from time to time. Picasa gives you the option to burn your photos on to optical discs. Go to Tools > Backup Pictures, select New Set and give a name to it. Also mention what formats you want to save and if you'd like to save the backup into a different folder or a network drive by clicking on Disk-to-disk backup. Click Create to finish. Now check the checkboxes for the folders and albums you want to backup and select Backup.

In the location that you backed up the photos, you'll find PicasaRestore.exe, which you can run to restore the images to the original path.

Picasa also has a Gift CD feature—go to Folder > Create a Gift CD.



Backup photo albums to a drive or even on a CD to gift it to someone

Click on Add More to add more folders to the gift CD. Select the resolution for the photos using the Photo Size dropdown menu and give the CD a name. Finally, click Burn Disc to burn the CD.

Adding Captions

To add a caption to a photo, double-click on it and you will find a small text area at the bottom of the photo. Enter your caption here and hit [Enter]. To delete the caption, click the Delete this caption icon on the right. To view the captions while in the main photo index view, go to View > Thumbnail Caption > Caption.

Host Your Own Web Albums

If you don't want to use Google's online Web space to store your photos, you can upload them to your own personal Web site's FTP server. Right-click on the album you want to upload and select Export as HTML Page. Enter a name for the album title and the resolution that you want to export the images to. Click Next, choose a template from the list and click Finish. The finished page will be displayed in your default Web browser. You can upload that folder to your site and create a link to it from your main page.

There's a feature that Google claims as experimental but it allows you to upload the photos to the FTP server directly through Picasa. Go to Tools > Experimental > Publish via FTP. Again, select a resolution, a save location and a template. Now you'll be prompted to select an account. Click on Account Manager to create a new account. Click Add an Account and enter your FTP server information—address, user and password—and click OK. Now you can select your new FTP server and click OK.

EMAIL

Google never stops plugging new features into Gmail. We take a look through some of the more useful ones added recently.

Colour Labels And Organising

Labels and filters are a good way to sort e-mail. To create a label, go to Settings > Labels, give it a name and click on Create. Now your label will appear in a box to the left side of the window. Click on the blank box to the right of the label and select a colour to assign it to the label.

You can set labels to your mails manually by clicking the checkbox for the mail and clicking the dropdown menu for more actions and selecting the label of your choice. You can set more than one label to the mail.